

ROCK AND ICE

Most of the Antarctic islands are rugged and hostile, with high rocky peaks smothered in ice that flows down to the sea in glaciers. Some of them are chains of volcanic islands, which have erupted from earthquake zones where two plates of Earth's crust grind together. The islands are windy and cold, with frequent snowstorms, but their bleak beaches offer easy access to an ocean teeming with fish and other food.



Antarctic islands

The Southern Ocean surrounding Antarctica is dotted with islands. They are rocky, icy places, and some are active volcanoes, but they make perfect breeding sites for the seabirds and other animals that get their food from the ocean. Many have vast breeding colonies of seals and penguins. These islands are also the nesting sites of airborne wanderers such as albatrosses.

BREEDING BEACHES

The beaches attract female seals, which must give birth to their pups on land. Since the seal pups cannot swim right away, their mothers also feed them on the beaches, gathering in big groups. The male seals join them, hoping to mate with the females. But seals do not simply pair up. Each male tries to control as many females as possible, which leads to intense competition and rival males fighting each other on the beaches.

► SOUTHERN ELEPHANT SEALS

These half-grown male southern elephant seals on South Georgia Island are already practicing their combat skills.

